

India's AL QAEDA

The brazen strikes and its expanding agenda make the Pakistan-backed terror group a deadly foe for India, and now, the world

By Sandeep Unnithan and Ramesh Vinayak

It was an attack that shocked the world for its sheer scale and ruthlessness. The Mumbai mayhem, the first seaborne urban terror assault in over three decades, was carried out by an organisation that is as unpredictable as it is ingenious. It is also the perfect example of a Janus-faced terror outfit—the Lashkar-e-Toiba (LeT) or the ‘army of the pure’—which also camouflages itself as a benign welfare organisation. Indeed, the Jamaat-ud-Dawa (JUD), a moniker which it adopted after being banned by the US in 2001, calls it-

self ‘an Islamic relief and welfare organisation striving to provide humanitarian assistance to people in need’. The Lashkar-e-Toiba headquarters at Muridke, 40 km from Lahore, resembles a sprawling Islamic university with schools and libraries.

Today, thanks to the confession of Mohammad Ajmal Amir Kasab, the 21-year-old terrorist captured alive in Mumbai, security agencies have a detailed account of the military-style planning that went into the LeT’s Mumbai operation, and can see through the JUD as an elaborate facade.

“The Lashkar is a military arm of the ISI with an India-specific agenda,” says a senior intelligence official. In a mission statement titled ‘Why we are waging jihad’, the LeT urges the dismemberment of India. Indeed, many would argue that it typifies Pakistan’s policy towards India. Kasab told the Mumbai police that the attacks were directly supervised by the Lashkar’s operations chief Zakiur Rahman Lakhvi aka ‘chachaji’ and Abu Muzammil who controls the group’s operations in the Indian hinterland.

The 10-member Mumbai terror squad was part of a group of 32 who were present for training—16 were selected for an as yet unknown clandestine operation by Rahman. Thirteen others, including Kasab, were sent to Muridke where they were taught swimming and acquainted with the life of a fisherman at sea. It is unlikely that the recruits were told why they were being taken out there in motor launches and familiarised with the marine environment—the LeT has a policy of never revealing how operatives are finally inserted into the area of attack. Lakhvi spent three months in Karachi, personally seeing off the squad as they set sail on November 23 after postponing their earlier September 27 departure.

THE MASTER-
MIND OF 26/11,
ZAKIUR
RAHMAN LAKHVI

